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Lord, Help Me!

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Lord, Help Me!

“After going out from there, Jesus went to the region of Tyre and Sidon. A Canaanite woman from that area came and cried out, ‘Have mercy on me, Lord, Son of David! My daughter is horribly demon-possessed.’ But he did not answer her a word. Then his disciples came and begged him, ‘Send her away, because she keeps on crying out after us.’ So he answered, ‘I was sent only to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.’ But she came and bowed down before him and said, ‘Lord, help me!’ ‘It is not right to take the children’s bread and throw it to the dogs,’ he said. ‘Yes, Lord,’ she replied, ‘but even the dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their masters table.’ Then Jesus answered her, ‘Woman, your faith is great! Let what you want be done for you.’ And her daughter was healed from that hour.” —Matthew 15:21-28

Never underestimate the power of humble, persistent prayer by someone who approaches in faith. This Canaanite woman’s actions clearly demonstrate to us the faithful and continuous seeking of the Master until obtaining the joy for which our soul longs. James tells us:

“So confess your sins to one another and pray for one another so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person has great effectiveness.” —James 5:16

Addressing Jesus with the Messianic title of “Lord,” she begs for mercy for her demon-possessed daughter. Boldly, humbly, and seriously this woman cries out to Jesus. The devil had her daughter in a dire and dreadful hold and she comes seeking the Master’s mercy.

She first meets with the Lord’s silence; He answers her not a word. Sometimes, when our prayers appear to be unanswered, God is teaching us to pray all the more. The more we feel the burden, the more we should pray. Evidently, this woman is undeterred by our Lord’s silence. The disciples encourage Jesus to simply get rid of her. They are annoyed by her continuous crying out. The disciples seem to be more concerned with their own comfort. They want to silence her troublesome pleas rather than consider this poor woman’s difficult circumstances. Thankfully, Jesus never turns any away who willingly seek Him.

Jesus initially responds to His disciples, yet within this woman’s hearing, that His mission at that time is to the lost sheep of Israel. While the sun and rain and fruitful seasons were and are given to all nations, there were special favors for God’s

distinctive people, the Israelites. The woman breaks into the conversation and kneels before Jesus, again requesting His helping hand. His response is not what we are used to hearing from His kind lips: “It is not right to take the children’s bread and toss it to the dogs.

I believe we learn an important lesson in this encounter with Jesus. All who approach Christ must first realize their standing (or lack of it) before Him. The reality remains, if He were to present himself to us in all His glory, no flesh could raise their face from the ground. This dear woman argues not against the truth of her standing with Jesus, but asks Him to consider that while she is not a child around his table of great grace and blessings, she is like a dog under His table ... and even His dog is treated with kindness and mercy. She understands that any crumbs falling from the Lord’s precious table will sustain her.

In her humility, she is grateful to receive the “crumbs.” Nothing is gained by contradicting any word from Christ, even if His word seems harsh. Amazed at her great faith, Jesus commends her and grants her request.

The writer of Hebrews tells us:

“Now without faith it is impossible to please him, for the one who approaches God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him.” —Hebrews 11:6

Praise God that we who live on this side of the resurrection of Jesus no longer experience the distinction of either being “in” or “out” of God’s provision. As Christ-followers we have access to all that God so willing wants to give us!

Become More

“It was her faith that he commended. Several other graces shone brightly in her conduct here—wisdom, humility, meekness, patience, perseverance in prayer—but these were the results of her faith. Because faith, of all graces, honors Christ the most, he honors faith more than any other grace.” —Matthew Henry

Further Reflections

“When you call out to me and come to me in prayer, I will hear our prayers. When you seek me in prayer and worship, you will find me available to you. If you seek me with all your heart and soul, I will make myself available to you,” says the LORD.

‘Then I will reverse your plight and will regather you from all the nations and all the places where I have exiled you,’ says the LORD. ‘I will bring you back to the place from which I exiled you.’” —Jeremiah 29:12-14

“The one sole thing in myself in which I glory, is that I see in myself nothing in which I can glory.” —Catherine of Genoa